

IRANIAN AND MACEDONIAN INVASIONS

Continuous at-a-glance master • north-west frontier • evidence before legend

ACHAEMENID: longer incorporation, tribute, levies, Aramaic context

MACEDONIAN: short campaign, alliances, battles, garrisons and rapid fragmentation

MASTER ANSWER LINE

Limited territorial reach did not mean isolation: the invasions reworked a connected frontier through variable rule, local agency and selective long-term contacts.

01

TWO DISTINCT FRONTIER EPISODES

Achaemenid Macedonian bounded reach local agency

Longer Achaemenid incorporation and Alexander's 327-325 BCE campaign are not one invasion.

Later Seleucids and Indo-Greeks are successor histories, not Alexander's occupation.

Core space is Gandhara and the Indus-Punjab frontier, not the whole subcontinent.

ANSWER LINE: two unequal frontier encounters produced limited conquest but durable selective contact.

02

SOURCE FIREWALL

inscription relief Herodotus later narrative

- 1 Behistun, DNa and XPh prove claimed imperial inclusion, not surveyed borders.
- 2 Persepolis imagery represents imperial order; coins show circulation before sovereignty.
- 3 Arrian, Curtius, Diodorus, Plutarch and Justin transmit lost sources through later genres.

METHOD: name source -> state proof -> add date, genre, unit or attribution limit.

03

CONNECTED FRONTIER MAP

Hindu Kush Taxila Punjab rivers Makran

CLAIM Approach: Iranian plateau -> Hindu Kush -> Kabul/Swat -> Gandhara/Taxila -> Indus.

04

GEOGRAPHY: routes enabled movement, while terrain, rivers, supply and communities imposed friction.

CYRUS TO DARIUS TO XERXES

Cyrus caution

Darius

518/516 BCE

Xerxes

Cyrus II is a possible eastern antecedent; a securely mapped Indian conquest is unproved.

Darius: Gandara at Behistun; Gandara and Hindush in DNa; Scylax voyage reported.

Xerxes continues eastern country claims and troop obligations; control remained variable.

CHRONOLOGY: Darius is firmest; the 518/516 BCE date is a convention, not a conquest charter.

05

ROYAL GEOGRAPHY AND HERODOTUS

DNa

Apadana

360 talents

contingents

1Naqsh-e Rostam and Persepolis place eastern peoples inside a royal world of ordered diversity.

2Herodotus's twentieth district and 360 talents signal perceived wealth and extraction.

3Indian/Gandarian contingents and possible later mercenary or allied service show varied obligation.

LIMIT: royal rhetoric, Greek genre and uncertain units forbid modern audit or census readings.

06

SATRAPY, ARAMAIC AND KHAROSHTHI

satrapy

local mediation

Aramaic

right-to-left

CLAIMProvincial supervision could combine tribute, levies, routes and local intermediaries.

EVIDENCEImperial Aramaic supplies the strongest context for Kharoshthi's right-to-left structure.

LIMITKharoshthi adapted a model to Indo-Aryan sounds; inventor and exact transmission remain unknown.

VERDICT: imperial obligation was real, daily control uneven, and script transfer selective.

07

CONTACTS WITHOUT PERSIANISATION

Iranian and Macedonian Invasions • tile 2 • Herodotus • c. 450 BCE

Scylax

Scylax

Scylax

Scylax

dipi/lipi and capital parallels are bounded comparisons, not proof of copied Mauryan institutions.

TRAP: reject both total Persianisation and total denial of specific Achaemenid links.

ALEXANDER'S EASTWARD ROUTE

327 BCEAornosTaxilaHyphasis

- 1327 BCE highland campaigns preceded the Indus; Aornos identification remains debated.
- 2326 BCE: Ambhi at Taxila -> Hydaspes against Porus -> Chenab/Ravi -> Beas halt.
- 3326-325 BCE: Jhelum fleet -> Indus descent -> Malloi -> Patala -> divided return.

SCALE: Alexander reached the Beas, not the Ganga plain, and did not conquer India.

HYDASPES: TERRAIN AND TACTICS

feintupstream crossingcavalryelephants

CLAIMCraterus remained opposite Porus while Alexander reportedly moved a selected force upstream.

EVIDENCECavalry manoeuvre pressured the wings; elephants caused shock and could also disrupt formations.

LIMITGreek success was followed by Porus's restoration and enlargement as indirect rule.

SOURCE LIMIT: tactics, speeches, casualties and the Porus medallion remain textually mediated.

WHY ADVANCE STOPPED

fatiguetmonsoonlogisticsNanda reports

Years of campaigning, homesickness and replacement shortages weakened willingness.

Resistance and reports of eastern armies/elephants sharpened risk; exact totals are rhetorical.

Rivers, humidity, disease and supply distance raised the expected cost of further movement.

CAUSATION: a cumulative command-morale crisis, not Indian unity or one frightening number.

